

ARTIST COMMONS

What Am I Making?

The Ontology of Art: The Continental/Critical Lens

POST-SESSION TOOLKIT

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This toolkit accompanies the Artist Commons session *What Am I Making? The Ontology of Art*, Session 1b: The Continental/Critical Lens. Use it as a reference, a springboard for studio reflection, and a guide for further exploration.

Contents

- | Framework 1: Art as Reproducible Object (Benjamin)
- | Framework 2: Art as Truth-Event (Heidegger)
- | Framework 3: Art as Autonomous Practice (Adorno)
- | Framework 4: Art as Reorganization of Perception (Rancière)
- | Glossary of Key Terms

How to Use This Toolkit

This document presents four philosophical frameworks for thinking about what artistic practice is and what it does. These are not competing truths to choose between. Think of them as philosophical lenses you can apply to your own work. Each illuminates certain aspects of art-making while leaving others in shadow.

The goal is not to find the 'right' answer. The goal is to develop richer vocabulary for understanding your practice and to recognize when different frameworks might be useful for different purposes.

For each framework, you'll find:

- **Overview:** The core claim and key thinkers
- **Where It Breaks Down:** Limitations and what the framework can't account for
- **Accessible Reading List:** Entry points for further exploration
- **Further Reading:** Deeper texts for those who want to go further
- **Studio Exercises:** Reflective questions and practice-based activities

Remember: These frameworks are tools. Use them when they're useful. Set them aside when they're not.

01

Art as Reproducible Object

Technology transforms what art is, from ritual object to political tool.

Overview

Walter Benjamin was a German Jewish cultural critic and philosopher, part of the Frankfurt School tradition. He wrote in the 1920s–30s and died fleeing the Nazis in 1940. His most famous essay for art theory is *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction* (1935). This essay fundamentally changed how we think about photography, film, and now digital art.

For most of human history, artworks were embedded in religious and ceremonial life: painted in churches, cast as sacred sculptures, created as ritual objects. You went to them. They existed in one place, at one time. That's where their power came from. Benjamin calls this power **aura**: the unique presence of the artwork in time and space, its here-and-nowness, its embeddedness in place and tradition. Think about the Rothko Chapel in Houston: fourteen enormous dark paintings in an octagonal room. Photographs exist. Books reproduce them. But anyone who has been there will tell you it's not the same. The silence, the scale, the shifting light. That experience only exists there. That's aura.

Photography and film changed everything. They created perfect copies. Infinite copies. The Mona Lisa can be on a postcard, a t-shirt, your phone. You don't need to go to the Louvre. As copies multiply, the original's unique presence weakens. Benjamin's radical claim: this isn't a loss. Destroying aura democratizes art. It breaks art free from ritual, from the church, from the elite spaces that controlled access. Art enters the street, the cinema, the pamphlet. It becomes available for politics instead of worship.



Left: Walker Evans, *Alabama Tenant Farmer Wife*, 1936, gelatin silver print, 20.9 x 14.4 cm, (The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York); right: Sherrie Levine, *After Walker Evans*, gelatin silver print, 12.8 x 9.8 cm (The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York)

Sherrie Levine, After Walker Evans: 4, 1981

Key Thinkers

Walter Benjamin (1892–1940): His central claim is that technology doesn't just change how art is made or distributed. It changes art's fundamental nature. Aura doesn't survive mechanical reproduction. And for Benjamin, that's politically progressive.

Sherrie Levine (b. 1947): An American artist central to the Pictures Generation. Levine rephotographed Walker Evans's Depression-era photographs and presented them as her own work, titled *After Walker Evans*. She makes Benjamin's argument into art: where is the original? Where is the aura? The images are visually identical, but everything about what they mean has changed. For anyone working with found images, appropriation, remix, or sampling, Levine proved that working with reproduction as subject is a legitimate and powerful artistic practice.

Trevor Paglen (b. 1974): A contemporary artist and geographer who makes art about seeing itself. *They Took the Faces from the Accused and the Dead* (2019) consists of faces scraped from the internet and fed into facial recognition training datasets. Real people whose images were collected without human viewers ever being intended. Paglen pulled them out and displayed them as art. This is where Benjamin gets pushed beyond what he imagined: most images produced today are never seen by human eyes. What does aura mean when there's no viewer? What does reproduction mean when the "original" is a dataset?



Trevor Paglen, They Took the Faces from the Accused and the Dead, 2019

Where It Breaks Down

Benjamin's claim that aura is reactionary and reproduction is progressive doesn't survive contact with the world artists actually work in. The Rothko Chapel is auratic, site-specific, and irreproducible, yet it's also free, open to everyone, and

has been a center for human rights work since the 1970s. His framework has no category for something that's both. The Mona Lisa is the most reproduced image in history, yet millions stand in line at the Louvre to see the actual thing. Reproduction didn't destroy the aura. It may have intensified it. Kusama's Infinity Rooms are literally made of mirrors, where reproduction is the medium, yet people wait hours for 30 seconds inside because the experience can't be reproduced. Benjamin gives us the vocabulary (aura, reproduction, ritual, politics), but his clean binary breaks down in practice. The tension is where the interesting work happens.

Accessible Reading List

"The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction", Walter Benjamin (1935)

The foundational essay. Plan for 30–45 minutes. *(Free)*

"Ways of Seeing," Episode 1, John Berger (1972)

BBC television series that translates Benjamin into accessible visual analysis. Episode 1 focuses directly on aura and reproduction. 30 minutes. *(Free)*

Sherrie Levine, After Walker Evans, MoMA Collection

Levine's work with reproductions, viewable in the MoMA online collection with critical context. *(Free)*

Further Reading

Illuminations, Walter Benjamin (essays, 1955/1968)

The best collection of Benjamin's essays, including "The Work of Art" and "The Storyteller." Translated by Harry Zohn, introduced by Hannah Arendt. *(Free to borrow, Internet Archive)*

On Photography, Susan Sontag (1977)

Extends Benjamin's analysis into a sustained meditation on how photography transforms our relationship to reality, memory, and experience. *(Free to borrow, Internet Archive)*

"Invisible Images (Your Pictures Are Looking at You)", Trevor Paglen (2016)

Paglen's essay on machine vision and operational images, extending Benjamin into the age of AI. (*Free*)

Studio Exercises

Exercise 1.1: The Aura Inventory

Think about your own work: Does it have aura? If yes, where does it live? The object itself, a specific space, the viewer's presence, or somewhere you can't quite name? If it doesn't have aura, or doesn't need it, what does your work do in the world instead? There's no right answer here. Benjamin himself couldn't pick one. That's what makes it a real question.

Exercise 1.2: The Distribution Question

Every time you decide how your work enters the world (limited edition or open access, site-specific or traveling, physical or digital), you're taking a philosophical position. Map one piece of your work: How does it circulate? Who reaches it? What would change if it circulated differently? What would be lost or gained?

Exercise 1.3: The Reproduction Test

Take one piece of your work and imagine it existing only as a digital reproduction, viewable everywhere, downloadable by anyone. Now imagine it existing only as a unique object that must be visited in person. Which version feels more true to what the work is? What does your answer reveal about where you think the work lives?

02

Art as Truth-Event

Art doesn't represent truth. Art is where truth happens.

Overview

The Greeks had a word for truth: *aletheia*. It literally means unconcealment, un-hiddenness. The word's structure tells you something: truth is what's not hidden.

Martin Heidegger (1889–1976) was a German philosopher working in the phenomenological and existential tradition. His major contribution to art theory is *The Origin of the Work of Art* (1930s). Heidegger asks: where does art come from? His answer is radical. Art doesn't come from the artist's skill or creativity. Art comes from truth happening. A painting or a sculpture doesn't point at something true. It creates an opening where something hidden gets unconcealed.

His famous example: a Greek temple. The temple doesn't represent anything. But it gathers a world around it. Before the temple, the landscape was just rocks and sky and earth. The temple makes the landscape *appear* differently. It makes the rock appear as rock, the sky as sky. It creates a space where things show themselves. Art is the struggle to make a world visible while the earth, the material ground, resists full disclosure.

A note: Heidegger was a member of the Nazi party. This is a real and serious problem, and scholars debate whether his philosophy can be fully separated from his politics. The art theory is genuinely useful regardless, but you should have this context.

The philosopher Alva Noë (b. 1964), in *Strange Tools* (2015), extends Heidegger's idea into more accessible language. We all have organized activities (ways of seeing, moving, speaking, paying attention) that we do automatically. We look right through them. Art takes those activities and puts them on display. It disrupts habitual perception and forces us to see what we normally don't notice. This is Heidegger's disclosure, translated into everyday experience.



The Parthenon, Athens. Heidegger's example of the world-gathering work of art

Key Thinkers

Martin Heidegger (1889–1976): Art is an event of truth. It creates an opening where something concealed gets unconcealed. This is different from representing truth or communicating truth. Art makes truth happen.

Alva Noë (b. 1964): Art as "strange tool." We use ordinary tools without thinking about how they work. Art works the same way with our organized activities. It takes what we do automatically and puts it on display, making visible the structures of experience we normally live inside without noticing.

James Turrell (b. 1943): Has worked with light and perception for over fifty years. His Skyspaces are rooms with an opening cut in the ceiling. At dawn or dusk, the sky in the opening starts to look like a flat panel of color. It detaches from depth, appears as a surface, a shape, a material. The sky appears as sky. This is almost literally Heidegger's temple example. Turrell isn't representing anything. He's creating conditions for disclosure.



James Turrell, Skyspace installation

Anicka Yi (b. 1971): A Korean-American artist known for installations working with biological processes, scent, and sensory experience. Her Tate Modern Turbine Hall commission *In Love With the World* (2021) featured floating machine-lifeforms drifting slowly through the hall. Her materials are alive, decaying, transforming. What does Yi's work unconceal? The hidden biological world. In her installations, the air itself feels alive; the boundary between your body and environment becomes uncertain. She unconceals something about how we exist as biological beings in a shared ecology.



Anicka Yi, In Love With the World, Tate Modern Turbine Hall, 2021

Where It Breaks Down

Three problems with Heidegger's framework:

First, it can make anything sound profound. "This work discloses the being of..." You can finish that sentence with almost anything and it sounds deep. The framework is close to unfalsifiable. Noë's translation helps: "Does this work reorganize how you perceive something?" is more testable.

Second, it privileges phenomenological, immersive, experiential art over others. What about conceptual art that's deliberately flat, anti-experiential? On Kawara made paintings of the date. Just the date, every day for decades. What does it unconceal? The being of Tuesday? John Baldessari wrote "I Will Not Make Any More Boring Art" over and over on canvas. Martin Creed won the Turner Prize for an empty room with the lights going on and off. Heidegger's framework has nothing to grip onto here.

Third, the Nazism question. Heidegger's philosophy of "gathering" and "world-making" has uncomfortable resonances with *völkisch* nationalism. Some scholars argue you can't cleanly extract the art theory from the political commitments. Worth sitting with.

Accessible Reading List

Strange Tools: Art and Human Nature, Alva Noë (2015)

The most accessible entry into this territory. Noë translates Heidegger's insights into clear, practical language. Begin here. (~\$14 Kindle)

"*The Origin of the Work of Art*", Martin Heidegger (1935–37)

The key text. Dense but rewarding. The Greek temple and Van Gogh's shoes sections are most accessible. (Free, *Academia.edu*)

James Turrell interviews and artist talks

Turrell speaks thoughtfully about perception and light. Many interviews freely available. (Free)

Further Reading

Poetry, Language, Thought, Martin Heidegger (1971)

The essential Heidegger collection for art and language, including "The Origin of the Work of Art." (Free to borrow, *Internet Archive*)

Anicka Yi: In Love With the World, Tate Modern

Exhibition page with video documentation and critical context for Yi's Turbine Hall commission. (Free)

Being and Time, Martin Heidegger (1927)

The major philosophical work underlying everything else. Division I on "being-in-the-world" is prerequisite for fully grasping the art essay. (Free to borrow, *Internet Archive*)

Studio Exercises

Exercise 2.1: The Disclosure Question

Think about one piece you've made. What does it unconceal about the nature of something? Not who gets seen (that's Rancière). This is about what your work reveals about how things *are*. The nature of materials, of space, of perception, of time, of being in a body.

Exercise 2.2: The Strange Tool Test

Using Noë's language: what organized activity does your work put on display? What does your audience do automatically that your work makes them notice? Turrell takes looking at the sky and unconceals it as an act of perception. Yi takes being a body in an environment and unconceals its strangeness. What's your version of that?

Exercise 2.3: The World/Earth Tension

Heidegger says art is the struggle between world (meaningful context) and earth (material resistance). What is the "earth" in your practice? The material or medium that resists, that won't be fully controlled? How does that resistance contribute to the work?

03

Art as Autonomous Practice

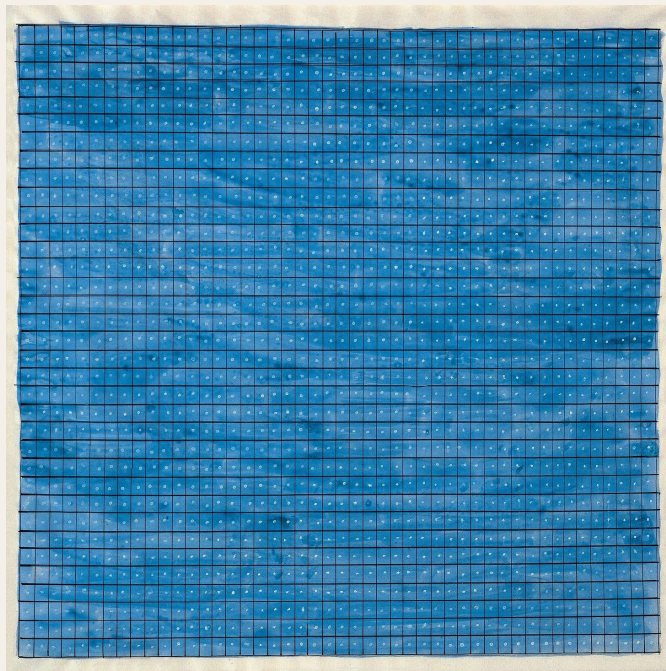
Art serves society best by not serving it.

Overview

Under capitalism, everything becomes commodity. Entertainment, music, culture, even art gets industrialized and standardized. The culture industry produces predictable, consumable products that reinforce the status quo: Hollywood, pop music, mass media, the algorithm. All designed to be consumed smoothly and forgotten.

Theodor Adorno (1903–1969) was a German philosopher and music theorist, part of the Frankfurt School alongside Benjamin. His major work on art is *Aesthetic Theory* (1970), published after his death. Adorno's core claim: art serves society best by *not* serving it. Art's autonomy, its refusal to be useful, is what makes it politically and socially valuable. Real art resists commodification by refusing to give easy pleasure, by being difficult and challenging. Autonomous art maintains independence from market demands and is more politically powerful than explicitly political art or propaganda. Why? Because autonomous art refuses the logic of capitalism entirely. It won't be instrumental. It won't tell you what to think. It makes you work.

The art historian Claire Bishop extends Adorno's argument into contemporary practice in *Artificial Hells* (2012). Her target is participatory and social practice art. Her argument: just because art is participatory doesn't make it politically meaningful. A lot of social practice art is too nice. It creates feel-good community moments, everyone collaborates, everyone leaves warm. But where's the friction? If nobody's uncomfortable, the work has been absorbed into the logic of consensus. For Bishop, art that works politically is antagonistic. It creates dissensus, not consensus.



Left: Shepard Fairey, HOPE, 2008. Right: Agnes Martin, grid painting. Adorno's paradox in visual form: mass-consumed iconography versus art that resists easy consumption.

Key Thinkers

Theodor Adorno (1903–1969): Art's political power comes from refusal. The more art resists easy consumption, the more it maintains a space capitalism can't reach.

Claire Bishop (b. 1971): Art historian and critic who extends Adorno into contemporary practice. Her book *Artificial Hells* (2012) argues that participatory art isn't automatically political. Genuine political art creates antagonism, not consensus.

Santiago Sierra (b. 1966): A Spanish artist who makes deliberately uncomfortable, confrontational work about labor and exploitation. In *250 cm Line Tattooed on 6 Paid People* (1999), Sierra paid six unemployed young men in Havana \$30 each to have a continuous line tattooed across their backs. His argument: the exploitation isn't his. It's the economic system that makes people willing to be permanently marked for \$30. He just made it visible. From an Adornian perspective, this is art that maintains its autonomy. You can't consume it pleasantly. You can't walk away feeling good. It refuses to resolve.



Santiago Sierra, 250 cm Line Tattooed on 6 Paid People, Havana, 1999

Theaster Gates (b. 1973): Gates buys abandoned buildings on Chicago's South Side, renovates them, creates cultural centers, archives, and housing. From an Adornian perspective, this has given up autonomy. It's instrumental, useful, serves a social function. But many contemporary critics argue this IS valuable art precisely because it does things in the world. Gates challenges Adorno directly: what if art's political power comes from engagement, not refusal?



Theaster Gates, Stony Island Arts Bank, Chicago

Where It Breaks Down

Three problems:

First, the dead end. If commercial success means compromise, and accessibility means absorption, what's the artist supposed to do? Starve? Make work nobody sees? That's not a theory of art. That's a theory of martyrdom.

Second, the eurocentrism. Adorno measured everything against European classical music. He couldn't hear jazz. He imposed the standards of Schoenberg onto a Black American art form and dismissed it as entertainment. That's not just wrong. It reveals a structural bias that privileges one cultural tradition and can't recognize innovation outside it.

Third, accessible doesn't mean absorbed. Carrie Mae Weems's *Kitchen Table Series* is immediately readable, emotionally powerful, widely reproduced, and one of the most important bodies of photographic work in the last 30 years. Yinka Shonibare's Victorian mannequins in African Dutch wax print fabric are hugely popular at museums and sharp postcolonial critique. Do Ho Suh's fabric replicas of childhood homes are visually stunning and deeply serious work about displacement. Adorno's framework can't account for these. It would have to call them compromised. That feels wrong.

But here's what Adorno gives you that no other framework does: permission to refuse. Every time you protect your work from being easy, every time you resist making something more palatable because the work demands it, you're drawing on Adorno whether you know it or not.

Accessible Reading List

Artificial Hells: Participatory Art and the Politics of Spectatorship, Claire Bishop (2012)

The most accessible entry into this territory for contemporary artists. Bishop applies Adorno directly to social practice. (~\$20, *Verso Books*)

"The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception", Adorno & Horkheimer (1944)

The chapter from *Dialectic of Enlightenment* that launched the critique of mass culture. Dense but essential. (*Free*)

"Against Interpretation", Susan Sontag (1964)

Not Adorno directly, but a productive counterpoint. Sontag argues for an erotics of art rather than a hermeneutics. (*Free to borrow, Internet Archive*)

Further Reading

Aesthetic Theory, Theodor Adorno (1970)

The major work. Dense and demanding. Robert Hullot-Kentor's translation (University of Minnesota Press) is standard. (*Free to borrow, Internet Archive*)

Participation, Claire Bishop, ed. (2006)

An anthology of primary texts on participatory art from Brecht through contemporary practice. (~\$25, *MIT Press / Whitechapel*)

Relational Aesthetics, Nicolas Bourriaud (1998)

The alternative view: art as social practice that creates new forms of human connection. Read alongside Bishop for productive tension. (~\$20)

Studio Exercises

Exercise 3.1: The Autonomy Audit

Where does your work fall on the spectrum between autonomous (art for its own sake, resistant to consumption) and instrumental (art that does something, serves a function)? Map your last three projects. Is that where you want to be?

Exercise 3.2: The Refusal Question

Is there something your work refuses? Something it won't make easy, won't explain away, won't resolve? If yes, what is it, and is that refusal intentional or incidental? If no, what would it mean to introduce refusal into your practice?

Exercise 3.3: The Community Test

If you make participatory or community-oriented work, apply Bishop's test: When your audience engages with your work, are they being challenged or being comforted? Is there friction? If everyone leaves feeling good, ask: did the art do anything? Is that okay with you?

04

Art as Reorganization of Perception

Art redistributes the sensible. It reorganizes what can be seen, heard, said, and thought.

Overview

After Adorno's dead-end (where commercial success means compromise and accessibility means absorption), our fourth framework offers a way out.

Jacques Rancière (b. 1940) is a contemporary French philosopher. His major works on art are *The Politics of Aesthetics* (2004) and *The Emancipated Spectator* (2009).

The core claim: at any given time, there's a **distribution of the sensible**: a configuration of what's visible and invisible, audible and inaudible, sayable and unsayable. This isn't just about censorship or who has a platform. It's about what even counts as something worth perceiving. Certain people's speech might be heard as communication while others' speech is heard as just sound. These distributions are political. They organize who gets to participate in common sense-making, who counts as a legitimate speaker, what problems are visible.

Art is whatever redistributes this. It makes visible what was invisible, reconfigures what counts as meaningful perception. Crucially, art doesn't do this through message or content primarily. It does this through **formal operations**, through how it organizes perception. Art is always political, but not through having political messages. Art is political because it reorganizes the sensible.

How does this differ from Heidegger's unconcealment? Think about Van Gogh's *Peasant Shoes*. Heidegger looks at that painting and asks: what does this reveal about the *nature* of these shoes? The earth clinging to the sole, the wear of labor. Rancière looks at the same painting and asks a completely different question: why is a peasant's shoe a worthy subject for painting at all? That's a political disruption. Heidegger is about things. Rancière is about people. Same painting, completely different question.



Vincent van Gogh, A Pair of Shoes, 1886. Heidegger and Rancière ask completely different questions about this image.

Key Thinkers

Jacques Rancière (b. 1940): Art redistributes the sensible through formal operations. The politics is in the redistribution, in what you make visible and sayable, not in having political content. This means accessible, beautiful, even popular art can be fully political. You don't have to choose.

Kerry James Marshall (b. 1955): Makes large-scale paintings of Black life and Black bodies using intense black paint mixed with his own formulations. The politics is in making Black bodies and Black domestic life monumentally visible in a way that challenges art-historical distributions of what's worth painting at scale. When a Marshall painting hangs in the same gallery as a Velázquez or a Rembrandt, something shifts about what that space says is worth looking at. His work is also formally accomplished and richly painted. Accessible and politically powerful simultaneously.



Kerry James Marshall, Our Town, 1995

Torkwase Dyson (b. 1973): Works with painting, sculpture, and architecture under a framework she calls "Black Compositional Thought," investigating how Black and Brown bodies navigate constructed environments. Her large geometric abstractions reference the spatial politics of the Middle Passage, water infrastructure, and architecture. They redistribute who gets to be perceived as a spatial subject, making visible that moving through space is a political experience.



Torkwase Dyson, Way Over There Inside Me (A Festival of Inches), 2023

Forensic Architecture: A research collective based at Goldsmiths, University of London, led by architect Eyal Weizman. They use architectural tools, 3D modeling, satellite imagery, and open-source media to investigate human rights violations. For the Syria project, they reconstructed Saydnaya Prison, a secret detention center where prisoners were kept blindfolded for years. Survivors couldn't describe what they saw. Forensic Architecture used "ear witnessing" (survivors identifying sounds, echoes, the clang of specific doors) to build a 3D model of a building designed to be invisible. After Grenfell Tower, they reconstructed the disaster minute by minute to show how corporate cost-cutting made it inevitable. This is Rancière in its purest form: taking what powerful people designed to be invisible and making it perceptible, sayable.



Forensic Architecture, satellite imagery of Saydnaya Prison, Syria, 2016. Imagery © DigitalGlobe.

Where It Breaks Down

Rancière's framework has the opposite problem from Adorno's. Adorno's was too restrictive. Rancière's is almost too permissive. If art is whatever redistributes the sensible, what doesn't qualify? A protest sign redistributes. A viral tweet redistributes. A well-designed ad campaign redistributes. At some point, if everything is redistribution, the concept stops doing useful work.

There's also a subtler problem: "making visible what was invisible" can become its own formula. Curators and grant applications love this language. "My work makes visible the..." You can finish that sentence with almost anything and it sounds politically serious. When a framework can absorb everything, it stops helping you distinguish good work from bad.

But here's what Rancière gives you that nothing else does: a framework where accessibility, beauty, pleasure, and political power can coexist. You don't have to choose between making work people want to look at and making work that does something in the world.

Accessible Reading List

The Emancipated Spectator, Jacques Rancière (2008/2009)

More accessible than *The Politics of Aesthetics* and directly addresses the relationship between art and its audience. (*Free to borrow, Internet Archive*)

"Ways of Seeing", John Berger (1972)

A brilliant, accessible application of similar ideas: how images distribute visibility and whose experience gets represented. (*Free, YouTube, Episode 1*)

Kerry James Marshall: Mastry, MCA Chicago (2016)

The major retrospective exhibition. Website includes images and critical context. (*Free*)

Further Reading

The Politics of Aesthetics, Jacques Rancière (2000/2004)

The foundational text. Short but demanding. The introduction and final interview are most accessible. (*Free to borrow, Internet Archive*)

Dissensus: On Politics and Aesthetics, Jacques Rancière (2010)

Essays collecting Rancière's applied work across art, film, and politics. (*Free to borrow, Internet Archive*)

Forensic Architecture: Saydnaya Prison, Interactive investigation

The full explorable 3D model of Saydnaya, reconstructed from survivor testimony. (*Free*)

Studio Exercises

Exercise 4.1: The Visibility Question

What does your work make visible, audible, or sayable that wasn't before? This could be about who or what gets represented, about new ways of perceiving, about revealing hidden structures, or about reorganizing who gets to participate. Be specific. Not just "I make visible..." but *what specifically*, and for whom, and through what formal means.

Exercise 4.2: The Form/Politics Question

Rancière insists the politics is in the form, not the content. Take one piece of your work. How do its formal choices (scale, material, placement, duration, mode of address) do political work? What would change politically if you made the same content with completely different formal choices?

Exercise 4.3: The Consensus/Dissensus Test

Does your work create consensus (everyone leaves feeling included, warm, understood) or dissensus (genuine friction, reconfigured perception, something unresolved)? Is that where you want it to be? Can accessible, beautiful work also create dissensus? Give an example from your own practice or from work you admire.

Glossary of Key Terms

Aesthetic Regime

Rancière's concept for the current historical organization of art, roughly since the late 18th century. In the aesthetic regime, art is defined by a specific kind of experience and by the breaking down of hierarchies between subjects, between high and low, between what's worthy of representation and what's not.

Aura

Walter Benjamin's term for the unique presence of an artwork in time and space, its here-and-nowness, its embeddedness in a place, tradition, and moment. Mechanical reproduction destroys aura by creating perfect copies.

Autonomous Art

In Adorno's framework, art that maintains independence from market demands, social functions, and instrumental purposes. Autonomous art refuses to be useful, and this refusal is, paradoxically, its greatest social value.

Culture Industry

Adorno and Horkheimer's term for the industrial production and standardization of culture under capitalism. The culture industry produces consumable, predictable products designed to pacify audiences and reinforce the status quo.

Disclosure / Unconcealment (Aletheia)

Heidegger's concept of truth as unconcealment, making visible what was hidden. In his art theory, art is one of the privileged sites where truth-as-disclosure occurs.

Distribution of the Sensible

Rancière's term for the configuration at any given moment of what is visible and invisible, audible and inaudible, sayable and unsayable. This distribution is political. It determines who counts as a legitimate perceiver, speaker, or participant.

Dissensus

Rancière's term for the disruption of existing consensus about what is perceptible. Art creates dissensus when it reconfigures the distribution of the sensible, not by having oppositional content, but by reorganizing perception itself.

Frankfurt School

A tradition of critical theory centered at the Institut für Sozialforschung in Frankfurt, Germany, from the 1930s onward. Key figures include Adorno, Horkheimer, Benjamin, and Marcuse. Characterized by combining Marxist social analysis with philosophical, cultural, and psychoanalytic methods.

Mechanical Reproduction

Benjamin's term for the technological capacity to create perfect copies of artworks, initially through photography and film, now through digital reproduction.

Redistribution of the Sensible

Rancière's term for what art does when it succeeds politically. It reorganizes what can be seen, heard, said, and thought. Redistribution happens through formal operations, not through political content.

Strange Tool

Alva Noë's concept. Ordinary tools are used without reflection. Art is a "strange tool" because it disrupts the automatic functioning of our organized activities. It takes something we do without thinking and puts it on display.

World / Earth

Heidegger's terms for the tension at the heart of artworks. "World" is the meaningful context the artwork opens up. "Earth" is the material ground that resists full disclosure. Art is the productive struggle between world and earth.